

01

## THE THREE POSITIONS □

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Exclusivism: only one religion is true; salvation is found only within it; other faiths are false. □ The lapidary Latin tag is *extra ecclesiam nulla salus* ("outside the Church there is no salvation"). □□ Attribution discipline: the doctrine is standardly traced to Cyprian of Carthage (d.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Inclusivism: one's own religion is the fullest truth, but other religions contain partial truth and their adherents may be saved through it (Karl Rahner's "anonymous Christians").

### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

258), whose own wording in Epistle 73 is *salus extra ecclesiam non est* — "there is no salvation outside the Church"; he also writes that one cannot have God as Father who does not have the Church as mother (De Ecclesiae Catholicae Unitate 6).

### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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**ANSWER LINE:** **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition):** Exclusivism reserves decisive truth or salvation for one tradition, inclusivism admits truth elsewhere under one fulfilment, and pluralism treats multiple traditions as independently valid responses to ultimate reality.

02

## THE VEDANTIC / INDIAN MODEL (2025 PYQ) □

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

"Ekaṃ sad viprā bahudhā vadanti" — Ṛgveda 1.164.46, from the *asya vāmasya* riddle-hymn ascribed to Dīrghatamas — "the one existent, the wise speak of in many ways". □□ Attribution discipline (examiner-visible): (i) cite the reference as RV 1.164.46, not vaguely as "the Vedas"; (ii) the verse's own context is the naming of deities — it lists Indra, Mitra, Varuṇa, Agni, the celestial Garutmān, Yama and Mātariśvan as names of "the one existent" — so its native subject is the unity of the Vedic pantheon, not the unity of the world's religions; (iii) its extension into a charter of inter-religious pluralism is a nineteenth- and twentieth-century development (Vivekananda, Radhakrishnan, Gandhi) and must be argued for, not asserted by citation; (iv) common transliteration variants (*ekaṃ sat vipra bahudhā vadanti*) are acceptable, but keep one form consistently. □ Used with that discipline it remains the strongest single Indian text for the pluralist case — precisely because it distinguishes one referent from many names. □

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### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Vivekananda — Universal Religion: all religions are true, different paths to the same goal (the one Reality); they are stages/varieties suited to different temperaments — "as many faiths, so many paths." No religion should destroy another; harmony & acceptance (not mere tolerance). □

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**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM:** Vedāntic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

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03

## THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH (2022, 2024 PYQ) □□

**CONTEXT + EXACT CORE**

But one can hold that there is an Absolute Truth (the Real/Brahman) while recognising all religions as partial, perspectival approaches to it → an absolute referent with pluralist access.

**MECHANISM / ARGUMENT**

The worry (2022): “unquestionable acceptance of only one Absolute Truth will inevitably result in religious exclusivism” → and exclusivism breeds conflict/intolerance. □

**CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST**

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**UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE**

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04

## COMPARISON GRID □□

**CONTEXT + EXACT CORE**

□ The high-scoring line: belief in an Absolute (Real/Brahman) is compatible with pluralism if truth-claims are held as partial & perspectival (Anekāntavāda/Hick) — this defuses the “absolute truth → exclusivism → conflict” chain.

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05

## FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK □□

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1. □ Ekaṃ sat viprā bahudhā vadanti is conventionally rendered as one reality spoken of under many names; its modern pluralist use requires argument beyond citation.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. □ Hick's pluralist hypothesis relocates the centre from one religion to the transcategorical Real.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

2. □ Vivekananda presents religions as diverse paths appropriate to different dispositions and calls for acceptance rather than mere tolerance.

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06

## APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

10. [Truth is one] "'Truth is one, yet people perceive differently' — evaluate in the Indian context." (2018, 15m) → \$2 + RV 1.164.46 discipline + anekāntavāda.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. [Absolute truth] "'One Absolute Truth → religious exclusivism.' Discuss." (2022) → \$3.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. [Pluralism-conflict] "Does pluralism invite inter-religious conflict & destroy religion's truth?" (2023) → \$3.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: 1. [Vedantic] "Vedantic religious pluralism & Vivekananda's Universal Religion vs conflicting truth-claims." (2025, 20m) → \$2.

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07

## PARITY BENCH — Indian and Western resources for the same four problems □□

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pluralism must answer four distinct questions—truth, salvation, coexistence and epistemic humility—rather than treating social tolerance as proof that all doctrines are true.

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